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The Yale Political Quarterly

An Undergraduate Publication

VOLUME 22, NUMBER 1, NOVEMBER 2000



FOUNDED 1979

Gabriela Karabelnik

Elections: Corruption and Apathy

Scott Clarke

Only God Knows

Jack Rubin

A Cuban Policy for the Next Administration

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THE YALE POLITICAL QUARTERLY
PO Box 203245
New Haven, CT 06520-3245

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November 2000

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Elections: Corruption and Apathy

Gabriela Karabelnik

CARLOS SANTANA HAD JUST COME TO THE ROARING FINALE OF HIS SHOW: A SEA OF *giddy, rain-geared or muddied fans, both young and old, hushed as Santana began to speak. Our eyes strained toward the psychedelic, blue-lighted stage down below. "Friends, I want to tell you that this is it. One Love . . . (cheer from the crowd) This is Martin Luther King's dream, and our brother Bob Marley's. Unity!! Beyond the corruption of religion and politics...(a louder cheer). Things like this are what keep one brother from shooting another. Not this government. But brothers and sisters, I want to tell you, come November I want you to vote for Gore. Bush—he'll try to get you back to the plantations. Gore—he'll protect us Latino brothers, the Mexicans, the African Americans, all the minorities. So vote Gore. Thank you all! Goodnight!"*

Santana has made a "smooth" transition into the pop culture of our day. From fame as a Seventies guitarist and rocker he has again achieved success with a hot mix of Latino beats and new singers. Yet his speech made me wonder about the degree to which his concerns resonated with his audience, particularly the younger fans. One thing for certain is that being fed up with political corruption does not make Santana old-fashioned. Yet would his audience go home feeling empowered to get information about the election and vote? Or, would the fans go home, rate the degree of satisfaction attained through the concert, and immediately search for a next source of entertainment, like good little consumers? I assumed that the audience would tend towards the latter. But why? And what is and can be done to improve that situation? The causes of this voter apathy seem to lie in a complex relationship of actual political corruption and alienation of the voters, as well as self and culturally driven indifference.

One of the main sources of political corruption is the extent to which the wealthy are seen to be the only players who can wield influence in politics, or in this specific case, the presidential elections. This has been an especially relevant issue in this election, especially as emphasized by both McCain and Bradley. Bush and Gore have continued the debates, arguing over the ever present class divides. The discussions concerning Campaign Finance Reform actually go back to 1972, when a host of campaign scandals brought up two main concerns, which have been heightened in the past twenty-eight years[1]. Originally, people were making large contributions to candidates and parties, which raised worries about wealth buying political favors. Big money opened doors for wealthy special interests groups, not ordinary citizens, who were starting to feel estranged from politics. Furthermore, elections were seen as too expensive. Those with their own millions or access to other people's money would be able to run, while many potential candidates who lacked these resources or did not solicit funds from wealthy donors would be shut out. The Presidency was looking buyable.

Beginning with the early Seventies, the costs of running for President have skyrocketed. Since 1974, the Presidential race has been federally funded, but in order to qualify, candidates still have to raise millions of their own,

mainly to cover media-oriented costs, which account for 46% of both Bush and Gore's expenses[2]. The easiest and most efficient way to pay for these is to court wealthy donors, who send large amounts of money directly to the parties, to political action committees (PACs), inaugural committees, and legal defense funds. To combat this situation, in 1974, the Federal Election Campaign Act was passed which put caps on a candidates' use of personal wealth and limits on independent expenditures and contributions. But the 1976 Supreme Court Case *Buckley v. Valeo* repealed many of the FECA amendments as unconstitutional, stating that they violated free speech. Overall spending limits and limits on personal wealth were lifted. Hard money, the contributions an individual could make to candidates was limited to $1000 and to PACs $5000. Soft money, the contributions given for party-building efforts and not for direct support of federal candidates, was not restricted[3]. The Supreme Court ruled that in general, the spending should not be limited because "virtually every means of communicating ideas in today's mass society requires the expenditure of money,[4]" effectively concluding that spending money is commensurate with speech when money is spent for political expression. Limiting the amount of money would hinder associations from "amplifying the voices of their adherents[5]."

The Supreme Court decision and its enactment did not end the controversies, however. Some opposed the connection between political spending and free speech, outraged especially that the use of soft money hadn't been abolished. The issue of soft money has dominated much of the general discussion about campaign finance, even though it only contributes 15% to the total money raised by candidates and parties combined[6]. The concern is that while this money is not supposed to be used directly for candidates, in the end it helps them just as much as the party organizations. Others in favor of fewer or no restrictions are antagonized by the $1000 limit of campaign contribution: it seems inconsistent that one could spend as much money on one's own campaign as one wants, but cannot give more than $1000 dollars (which has not even been adjusted for inflation from the 1970 standards) to say, one's own brother, were he campaigning.

What further complicates the issue is party politics. Each party tries to maximize its own benefits in specific areas and hinder the other party, making reform very difficult. One way to approach the deadlock would be to appoint a non-partisan, independent commission that would suggest changes for Congress to pass. This is an extremely complex issue, and the impulse to regulate very closely what a candidate can spend and how much can be given to a campaign, as attractive and easy as it sounds, needs to be regarded in light of First Amendment rights. So yes, Santana is right and the audience agreed—politics is corrupt. With this important issue though, the answers aren't very clear—protecting the constitutional rights of the candidates and donors remains a sticky but important legal consideration.

This is an exremely complex issue, and the impulse to regulate very closely what a candidate can spend and how much can be given to a campaign, as attractive and easy as it sounds, needs to be regarded in light of First Amendment rights.

Another area in which the alienation of voters could be reduced is that

of media presentation of the candidates. It is also one of the issues in which election conditions and voter apathy go hand in hand. As is, the major exposure an average television viewer has to a candidate is through campaign ads. The amount spent on ads is six times that of 1972, and these ads have reduced political discourse to the "unattractive, synthetic, deceptive, out of context, and inflammatory[7]." For most of us, these ads are far from making the candidates appealing; instead, they bring forth disgust for politics, portraying it as a world of sound bites, plastic smiles and manufactured concern. Aware of this reaction, Clinton and Gore created an advisory board in 1997 with the object of directing the concerns of broadcasters to accomodate public interest. The committee report recommended that television networks air five minutes of candidate-centered discourse for 30 nights prior to an election. At the time, the typical local station and national networks each aired, on average, less than 60 seconds a night of candidate discourse[8].

In 1998 Paul Taylor, a former Washington Post reporter, founded the **Alliance for Better Campaigns,** backed by Jimmy Carter, Gerald Ford and Walter Cronkite. The group challenged the television industry to open the airwaves to brief nightly issue forums, made up of interviews, issue-statements, and mini-debates involving the presidential candidates. The goal was to recapture those viewers lost by the attack ads and sound bites that dominate politics back into the political sphere. Television provides viewers with information that they often are not actively seeking (unlike the Internet, made for the self-motivated), and these five minute slots would offer a way to see the candidates in a different, more substantial, often more spontaneous light, while keeping within the time limit of the average viewer's attention span. So at least we would get five solid minutes of substance. A second positive effect would be that every qualified candidate would have at least minimal access to public airwaves—giving the underfunded candidate who cannot afford all the ads a chance to make himself seen and heard on a broader scale. At the same time, the well-funded candidates could serve up as many ads as they wish.

The stock accusation of corruption served as a perfect excuse not to be informed or to care at all.

Much work still needs to be done in this area—since the commission's recommendation and the Alliance's efforts, almost all stations are still below the five-minute line. For the March 7 primary of this year, national networks averaged only 36 seconds a night of candidate-centered discourse, compared to the one hour per night of ad time[9]. This discouraging state of affairs contributes to voter apathy and cynicism, with too few ways to differentiate the candidates amidst all the jargon.

This cynicism is thus well founded in light of government and media shortcomings in catering to individual voters. Yet another, and in my view, central aspect of the question of voter apathy should not be neglected. A friend recently told me of her encounter with a group of high school students she was tutoring. She asked them about their thoughts on the election. "Oh, they're all so corrupt. Who cares which one you pick?" came the resounding response. My friend proceeded to ask them what they knew of the views of the candidates on certain issues, like abortion, gun control, etc.. " I dunno, I dunno," they replied, shrugging with a self-righteous indifference. The stock accusation of corruption served as a perfect excuse not to be informed or to care

at all. It seems that first, as a voter, I ought to concern myself with the issues at hand and explore how they would affect our country and our lives. Then the candidates could be assessed in terms of their stances on these positions. Only when I have determined that none of the candidates cares about the things I do, should I really start talking about the possible causes for that, which may include the problems surrounding big money. Of course I am cynical about the ad campaigns and the empty talk. But when I am abdicating my responsibility as a citizen to be informed about the issues, it should not be a surprise when the candidates do not feel held accountable to the interests of the general public.

With only 49% of the public voting, how is the President expected to be representing the nation's concerns? Out of the remaining 51%, certainly only a minority is not voting out of protest, because it does not identify with the interests voiced by either candidate. The majority of people are not voting because of apathy, not because of genuine concern.

Who cares about politics when I could be seeing Carlos Santana, going shopping or being entertained in some other way? Why should I be challenging myself, engaging my mind, when my culture has no expectations of me except to respond to my hedonistic whims? We need to teach the value of action, advocacy and voter responsibility from an early school age. We need to stop giving up before we have started, and fight this passivity that makes our politicians conclude that all they have to do is appeal to an MTV attention span and logo-dizzy mind. We need to watch the debates, go on the web, talk to each other, find out what is happening and decide how we should respond—at least with our votes if not with advocacy.

This is where we see Santana departing from our generation. The Sixties movements which he cites evidenced much dissatisfaction of the young with the government. Yet instead of shutting off, like many of us at the Santana concert, they decided to come together and advocate the things they cared about. Sure, politicians are under the influence of wealthy donors, and will probably continue to be. But they cannot afford to shut their eyes to thousands gathered under the windows of the Capitol, demanding to be heard. As part of the audience listening to Santana's speech, I found little inspiration in his celebration of our unity (in what? our wetness? our love for his music? our numbers?), or his political convictions (plantation? Who is talking about returning to plantations?). Nevertheless, the passion he had for his cause, and the conclusion he drew from these—vote!—makes him both a voice of the past, and hopefully, a herald for a brighter political future.

Why should I be challenging myself, engaging my mind, when my culture has no expect-ations of me except to respond to my hedonistic whims?

[1]www.prospect.org/archives/36/36marrfs.html
[2]www.bettercampaigns.org
[3]www.pirg.org/demos/cfr/hist.htm
[4]www.prospect.org/archives/36/36marrfs.html
[5]www.prospect.org/archives/36/36marrfs.html
[6]www.pirg.org/demos/cfr/hist.htm
[7]www.bettercampaigns.org
[8]www.bettercampaigns.org
[9]www.bettercampaigns.org

A Cuban Policy for the Next Administration

Jack Rubin

THE GOP CONGRESSIONAL LEADERSHIP ACHIEVED A REMARKABLE parliamentary feat in late July. Two amendments to the Treasury Appropriations Bill were passed through the House easing the embargo on food and medicine shipments to Cuba, as well as alleviating the travel restrictions applicable to that country. This proposal was then altogether re-done and attached to the Legislative Appropriations Bill without the two aforementioned amendments. When enacted, the second bill nullified the passage of those very high-profile amendments that brought so much media attention to the original legislation.

That is a mouthful, but essentially the amendments were used to get a little good publicity over the weekend and give Congress an appearance of having a commitment to ease the sanctions on Cuba. The press was baited and it bit down hard, only to realize a few days later they had been duped. They were tricked into reporting that Congress would soon turn the other cheek on the Cuban embargo. In truth, nothing of the sort would come to fruition that week or even that month. When Congress did finally enact similar legislation in mid-October in a mad rush to approve final appropriations bills before going into recess for the fall elections, they did so in conjunction with provisions that further restricted travel to Cuba and made it nearly impossible for Cuba to obtain credit from American firms for purchases of American goods.

Proponents of the original measures hope that easing the travel restrictions and exempting food and medicine from the embargo will be the first installments in a process of engagement that will begin the opening of Cuba to international media scrutiny and eventually lead to the democratization of the island's political scene. Representative Mark Sanford (R-SC) continues to press for the passage of H.R. 4471, a statute that would do what those two ill-fated amendments to the Treasury Bill failed to accomplish. But Rep. Sanford stands virtually alone in this election year, when few Republican Congressmen will challenge their own leadership over the embargo on Cuba. The prospects are not good for comprehensively lifting the sanctions in the foreseeable future. The result of this lengthy exposition is that we're more likely to see animal crackers appear on the endangered species list than to see Congress push forward with a meaningful easing of the embargo on Cuba any time before the next session.

The Cuban embargo question has been a thorn in the side of U.S.-Latin American relations for decades. As Congress remains deadlocked in partisan public relations and parliamentary jockeying, it is useful to look at the challenges the next U.S. President and the next Congress will face in dealing with the sole Communist island nation in the Caribbean. A fresh look at U.S.-Cuba relations is especially appropriate at this juncture. This is particularly the case given the heightened sensitivity of those relations

following the recent international custody battle for Elián Gonzalez and the growing American business interest in the island. It is time to discuss how the United States should engage Cuba in the coming years, what potential challenges may accompany this strategy, and what responses are likely to combat those challenges.

The Cuban government, in its present form, is fundamentally incompatible with the interests of democracy in the Western Hemisphere. Dissidents within Cuba are frequently jailed and otherwise repressed. Cuban exiles in the United States live with a strong desire to see their home island free of an oppressive regime. Yet, Cuban society on the island has been governed, shaped, and molded by the party apparatus for four decades. Uncertainty surrounding future U.S. Latin American policy strengthens the regime. It encourages people living in Cuba to believe that they can trust only a Castro (if not Fidel, then perhaps Raúl) to stand up to the supposedly impending U.S. invasion of the island nation. These facts, when taken on their own, portray a Cuba that is unapproachable at best. But, a persistent American Cold War mentality on the embargo, Elián, and U.S. security interests serve only to bolster the Castro regime and hinder real democratic change on the island.

The objective of U.S. policy toward Cuba should be to achieve a peaceful transition to democracy. Some argue that America should engage the Cuban people now, while others steadfastly insist upon waiting until Fidel's departure or death to begin softening relations. Both camps claim fiercely loyal followings.

One marked point of convergence in this remarkably divisive debate is that all sides do want the embargo lifted. The discussion centers on whether the end to the sanctions should come before or after Castro's departure. The Miami Cuban-exile community understandably favors maintaining the sanctions at least until assets expropriated since 1959 are returned to their original owners. Yet the embargo has not achieved the U.S. objective of forcing Cuba to allow for a more democratic political system, including free and fair multiparty elections. Nor has this objective been achieved by Canadian and European policies of heavy investment in the island. Castro remains firmly in power. US sanctions in which the rest of the world does not participate allow Cuba enough room to survive financially and provide Fidel a ready scapegoat for any economic troubles. Consequently, the government translates any economic successes into great political victories for Castro in his epic David and Goliath struggle with nine American administrations.

Cuba will have great economic potential as a democratic state, as evidenced by the example of the neighboring Dominican Republic. Since the establishment of the present democratic government, the nation has boasted an 8% growth rate for the last four years, the fastest growth rate in the world. Given her wealth of natural resources, ideal location, and famous history as a center for Caribbean trade, Cuba will have even greater potential for growth under a democratically elected government.

Drug Trafficking. America's security interests necessitate a new kind of relationship with the strategically positioned island of Cuba. In drug interdiction efforts, Cuba's full cooperation will be essential for real long-term success. Billions of dollars in American aid to Colombia and the other Andean nations to fight against the drug traffickers must be complemented by an international effort to stifle the

pipeline from South America to the United States and to Europe. U.S. and Cuban anti-drug agencies must be able to share intelligence and coordinate their drug interdiction efforts. The cooperation of the two nations is absolutely necessary at this stage in the war on drugs.

Fidel Castro. Good relations with other Latin American and European leaders are imperative for the softening of relations between Castro and any American administration. The release of jailed political dissidents that coincided with the visit to Cuba of Pope John Paul II in 1998 displayed Castro's potential to answer to international scrutiny when foreign press purposefully focuses on the island. The 1999 Iberio-American Summit held in Havana at which some of the participants voiced their public criticism of the Cuban government also exemplifies the kind of pressure prominent world leaders can place on the regime.

America has adopted a carrot and stick approach in dealing with many of its former Soviet-era adversaries and yet has subbornly placed a brick wall between itself and htis tiny island of elemen million inhabitants.

Yet these events did not go far enough to propel Cuba on the path to institutional reform and political freedom. They were not examples in a line of successive media encounters. When Fidel knows that what he does domestically has significant consequences for the relations Cuba maintains externally, he is more accountable for his actions and more responsible to his own people. America has adopted a carrot and stick approach in dealing with many of its former Soviet-era adversaries and yet has stubbornly placed a brick wall between itself and this tiny island of eleven million inhabitants. The next President and the next Congress should seek to build a consensus among Latin American leaders to encourage Castro to minimize repression, expedite economic reforms, and begin the long-overdue process of democratization.

Other Cuban Leaders. Starting in the 1980's, the Party and the government ministries began renewing their ranks with younger leadership to ensure the future of the Revolution and the Communist state. With the backing of a youthful party membership and high-level offices he holds, Raúl Castro, Fidel Castro's brother, is now the presumed successor to lead the Party and the government upon Fidel's death.

Governments and political parties all over the world would like to see a more open political system on the island, both to benefit the Cuban people and to invite committed, long-term foreign investment to the nation. The next elected government of the United States should make it clear to the other leaders on the island that, should they embrace democracy and begin the process of political reform, America will welcome them with open arms. This is not so far-fetched an idea. Consider the Communist parties of the Newly Independent States. In some of the former Soviet satellites following the dissolution of the U.S.S.R., the same leadership re-configured to form nationalist parties that survive to this day. A similar transition could succeed in Cuba.

Another Elián. The unhurried return of Elián Gonzalez to Cuba only perpetuates a view of the evil, imperial United States, one held hostage by a community of Cubans who have left the island to live abroad. A child in Elián's situation coming from any other country in the world would have been reunited with his father in his native country with little hesitation beyond verifying the parental claims of that father to his child.

Internationally recognized custody laws do not evaporate when a child leaves Cuban soil. If ever there is another Elián, he must be sent home directly.

Engagement Imperative. The strongest argument for fresh thinking on Cuba is that if Castro were to die today he would become a martyr for the Cuban Communist Party. He would be immortalized not just for what he accomplished through the 1959 Revolution, but also for his continued, decades-long struggle with the United States, ostensibly on behalf of the Cuban people. His death would carve for America an epitaph of antagonism and enmity. The new leadership would seek to consolidate power with a rebirth of Cold War rhetoric, solidifying the present state of U.S.-Cuba relations for perpetuity. Moreover, without a guaranteed peaceful transition following Castro's death, the U.S. would see a new deluge of boats packed to the brim with refugees, threats to the U.S. Naval Base at Guantánamo, and drug interests seeking to capitalize on the ensuing turmoil.

As the pendulum swings from Helms-Burton to the easing of the embargo, the next U.S. government has a milestone diplomatic opportunity to establish a program of engagement with Cuba. The peaceful transition to democracy must begin with America easing the restrictions on travel and remittances to the island, followed by lifting the embargo on food and medicine. Concurrently with Cuba's reinstatement of expropriated assets to their rightful owners, the U.S. should initiate cooperation with the Cuban government in the international arena while encouraging increased protections for foreign and native journalists on the island. Ultimately, following free and fair multiparty elections on the island, the democracies of the Western Hemisphere should invite Cuba to join in a trade association like the Caribbean Basin Initiative or the Free Trade Area of the Americas. This program of engagement is as realistic as it is optimistic. Such possibility for productive U.S.-Cuba interaction has not existed in over forty years. It is disadvantageous for all involved that the small island of Cuba should remain cut off from the world's sole superpower a mere 90 miles to its north. It is time for America to outgrow the silent treatment it so immaturely continues to inflict upon its Caribbean Cold War playmate.

In the last decade, America has entered a new era of diplomacy and commerce. Given the U.S. trade agreements established with China and Vietnam and the American aid pouring into North Korea and Russia, the U.S. can now turn toward opening up the last of the Cold War-era Communist holdouts in the Western Hemisphere, and indeed the world.

In order to bring Cuba back into the international community where she belongs, America will have to work for a better relationship with the Cuban people and their government *before* Castro is gone. To wait would be to risk alienating the island for another forty years while fueling the incendiary anti-American rhetoric of the Hugo Chávez's of the world. American leaders must work with Cubans both on the island and in the diaspora to forge a consensus for policy priorities. They need the cooperation of leaders from all over Latin America to establish a new program of engagement with Cuba and thus assist in her peaceful transition to democracy. The next president and the next Congress of the United States will enter office at an historic time when Cuba, once America's nearest potential nuclear threat, might become one of America's closest allies in trade and democracy.

Only God Knows

Scott Clarke

POPEYE HAD A GREAT SAYING: "I YAM THAT I YAM." HE WAS WHO HE WAS AND made no apologies for it. Indeed, separating what a person is and what he or she does is an impossible task. The inevitability of what lies inside pecking its way through the shell is axiomatic.

Forty years ago, the Democratic Party nominated a young Massachusetts politician named John Kennedy as its presidential candidate. He vowed to keep religion and politics separate, and became the country's first and only Roman Catholic president. Forty years later, candidate George W. Bush proudly proclaimed Jesus Christ as the thinker who has most influenced his life in a Republican debate that more resembled a testimony for a number of the candidates. Similarly, Al Gore has chosen Senator Joe Lieberman, an Orthodox Jew as his vice presidential running mate, who has quoted the Bible and directly mentioned God so many times since accepting his position on the ticket that it would be quite the task to tally up the specific instances. Clearly, present-day politics is permeated with religious references that appeal to the responsive constituency. What has changed since the great panic that JFK would be a mouthpiece for the Vatican? Many an "expert" would say President Clinton's shenanigans have brought morality discussions to the forefront. Still others would contend that a religious point of view has always been a given in the lives of most Americans and that they can no more separate that part of their identity from the decision-making process than cut off a hand. They may think about religion in a more pluralistic manner today, but they do nonetheless still think about it. Thus, the candidates are not only competing for the votes of the people, but for their hearts and minds as well. Although skepticism and cynicism reigns among today's voters, one can only judge the sincerity of a candidate's profession by watching his or her life.

Clearly, present-day politics is permeated with religious references that appeal to the responsive constituency.

Religion and morality are things about which the American people still care. The scandal over Bush's visit to conservative Christian Bob Jones University is a perfect example. Then presidential candidate Senator McCain had no idea he was opening Pandora's box with his comments about Bush's speech.[1] He counted on a general sense of outrage at Bush's choice to visit a university with controversial stances on Catholicism. That frame of thought led to McCain's attacks on religious leaders such as Pat Robertson for his politically conservative stances on social issues, not to mention that Robertson is an outspoken Protestant. McCain also made the fateful decision to focus campaign calls on Catholic voters he thought likely to be won over in Michigan.[2]. The results of McCain's choices show something very important about Americans. Many Americans still do take into consideration candidates' religious views. McCain could only elicit outrage if there existed people with strong opinions on the matter. His mistake was that he just did not foresee the powerful backlash from those he attacked. The political philosophies of Catholics and Protestants are by no means monolithic,

and far more sensitive to political [prodding] than McCain could have expected.

The bottom line is that most Americans do have some sort of religious affiliation. In fact, 88% of Americans say that religion is important in their lives.[3] Sixty-eight percent of Americans are members of a church or synagogue.[4] As much as America has secularized, it is still a nation of people who considers religion a part of their identity. As such, people also consider the preservation of morality important. For most, their religion also shapes their concept of morality. The two are inextricably linked. For Bush, this has translated into a great deal of popular support for his character. In spite of rumors, (which are probably true) that he used cocaine in his younger years, a character flaw otherwise likely to be fatal to political success, his story of repentance resonates with baby boomers on a general search for spirituality.[5] Many consider Bush a part of that American "culture."[6] He just "fits in."[7] Similarly, many have also found great comfort in the ease with which Senator Lieberman proclaims his faith. It defines who the candidates are, demonstrating their integrity with the willingness to stand behind it.

In light of these past eight years, the public wants a trustworthy candidate. It is little wonder that morally speaking Al Gore is trying his best to put light years of distance between himself and the President. Repeatedly he has made it clear to all that he loves his wife. The kiss heard around the world at the Democratic National Convention was transparently intended to convey the message to all watching. Moreover, Gore's choice of Senator Lieberman is intended to declare a profound difference between himself and Clinton.[8] Although the conventional wisdom is that Lieberman was fairly low in attractiveness on Gore's list of potential running mates, sources closest to Gore say Lieberman was always highly considered, in large part because of his reputation for integrity.[9] The Connecticut Senator openly denounced President Clinton's affair with Monica Lewinsky calling it "immoral." In the second debate with Gov. Bush, Al Gore himself said, "Our real power... comes from our values."[10] Gore also attempted to quote the Bible in defense of his own political values. On the campaign trail, Gore and Lieberman openly discuss faith on a regular basis as central to their lives.[11]

As such, people also consider the preservation of morality important.

Bush, furthermore, began the campaign with the profession that his faith is a cornerstone of his personal and political life. From the start of his official campaign, it was Bush's faith that he felt had changed him and brought him to where he was.[12] He called 1986 a watershed year. It was the year he quit drinking, sold his oil company, and became a born again Christian. Since entering the campaign, Bush has used his faith to deflect questions about his past. He has often said that details about his past may encourage young people to go the wrong way. He says he has changed and that that is all there is to it.[13] And he has managed to build a campaign on this experience. Then, of course, there were the primary debates in which Bush named Christ as his favorite thinker because "he changed my life." Bush has been able to strike first on the moral high ground. He has said time and again that if elected he would "restore honor and dignity to the office so help me God."[14] Who can argue with Bush's claims of repentance and absolution? This stance gives Bush the opportunity to use his faith to bring

"compassionate conservatism" into common vocabulary and dictate the terms of the campaign. His refusal to delve into the murky depths of his past appears righteous.

Of course, one worry is that the candidates are selling their religion and that they may not be genuine. After all, knowing that America is a nation on a spiritual journey, the candidates could take full advantage. They are only chasing likeability and a positive image some may say (see appearances on Oprah, Regis, and Larry King Live). The reality, though, is that one may never know if the candidates mean what they say. That is strictly a matter of the heart. Americans have placed themselves in the role of the consumer in almost every aspect of life. Thus, a strategy of deception on the part of the candidates may simply be fallout. It is only reasonable to expect a candidate competing for a vote to pander heavily to what the voter wants to hear. Sometimes the politician will boldly lie. Cynicism aside, however, religion is an integral part of a person's life and should reasonably be expected to influence all that they do. Most were able to overcome paranoia about Kennedy and the Pope, because their fears never came to fruition. Actions are the only measure by which one can judge the sincerity of claims uttered during a campaign. Hopefully, this new longing for a spiritual side to life has brought Americans to a point where they both expect and honor a candidate's commitment to his faith.

[1] Soskis, Benjamin, "Double Cross," The New Republic, 03 March 2000, Online: http://www.tnr.com/032000/soskis032000.html

[2] Soskis, Benjamin, "Double Cross," The New Republic, 03 March 2000, Online: http://www.tnr.com/032000/soskis032000.html

[3] Gallup Survey, August 2000, Online: http://www.gallup.com/poll/indicators/indreligion.asp

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[5] Fineman, Howard, "Praying to Win", Newsweek, 13 August 2000, Online: http://www.msnbc.com/news/445415.asp

[6] Cottle, Michelle, "More Like Us", The New Republic, 03 March 2000, Online: http://www.tnr.com/032000/cottle032000.html

[7] Fineman, Howard, "Praying to Win", Newsweek, 13 August 2000, Online: http://www.msnbc.com/news/445415.asp

[8] Fineman, Howard, "Praying to Win", Newsweek, 13 August 2000, Online: http://www.msnbc.com/news/445415.asp

[9] Second Presidential Debate, Online: http://abcnews.go.com/sections/politics/DailyNews/debate001011_trans_1.html

[10] Fineman, Howard, "Praying to Win", Newsweek, 13 August 2000, Online: http://www.msnbc.com/news/445415.asp

[11] Pooley, Eric and Gwynne, S.C., "How George Got His Groove," 21 June 1999, Online: http://www.time.com/time/magazine/articles/0,3266,26833-1,00.html

[12] Pooley, Eric and Gwynne, S.C., "How George Got His Groove," 21 June 1999, Online: http://www.time.com/time/magazine/articles/0,3266,26833-2,00.html

[13] Fineman, Howard, "Praying to Win", Newsweek, 13 August 2000, Online: http://www.msnbc.com/news/445415.asp

[14] Cottle, Michelle, "God Almighty", The New Republic, 09 September 1999, Online: http://www.tnr.com/archive/0999/090699/cottle090699.html

"Please put it in a bank....Please, let's put it in a foreign bank."
—**Vladmir Putin,** advising families of the Kursk submariners on what to do with their compensation, as quoted in the September 11, 2000 issue of *Time Magazine.*

"I've been a part of the discussions on the strategic reserve since the days when it was first established."
—Vice President **Al Gore**, at a press conference, referring to the Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPR), despite the fact that President Ford established the SPR when he signed the Energy Policy and Conservation Act on December 22, 1975, two years before Al Gore became a congressman, as quoted in the September 24 issue of *The Washington Post.*

"You of all people shouldn't try to make guilt by association."
—**Rick Lazio**, in his first debate with Hillary Clinton, after she linked him to Newt Gingrich, as quoted in the September 25 issue of *Time Magazine.*

"Pickup trucks, deer hunting, barefoot girls and boiled peanuts—that's what the flag represents...Nobody looks at it as a symbol of hate."
—Georgia state senator **Eric Johnson**, on the state flag, which has a large Confederate X, as quoted in the September 11 issue of *Time Magazine.*

"A year after I move to the state we have a subway series. That's pretty exciting."
—**Hillary Clinton**, as quoted by CNN Producer Phil Hirschkorn and Correspondent Frank Buckley on October 18.

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